

AMICUS EX MACHINA

Friend from the machine.

Written by Yelyzaveta Dolha

SCENE 1 — INT. DATA ROOM — DARK

A dark room. No windows.

The ANALYST walks in. No rush. Coat off, bag down. He pulls the chair out, sits. Opens the laptop -- the screen throws pale light across his face and the desk. Nothing else is lit.

He clips the lapel mic to his collar. Adjusts it once. Doesn't look at it.

Notepad pulled close. Pen uncapped and set down beside it -- not picked up yet. He's not writing yet. Nothing has happened yet.

He opens the queue on screen. Scrolls briefly. Stops. Leans back slightly. Arms on the desk.

The room is quiet. He waits.

This is the job. He's done it hundreds of times.

CUT TO:

SCENE 2 — EXT. ARTHUR'S FLAT — DAY

A doorstep. Morning light. A brown package sitting where someone left it.

ARTHUR picks it up. He's twenty-one. The kind of person who seems like they have things figured out not arrogant, just comfortable in himself. He tucks the box under his arm.

His flat is lived in. Warm.

He sets the box down. Opens it. Inside a small sleek device. A screen. A speaker. Designed to look friendly. Personal. Like something that belongs in a home.

He reads nothing on the packaging. Just plugs it in.

CUT TO:

SCENE 3 — INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT — CONTINUOUS

Arthur sets her up.

A grid of faces on screen — warm, designed to feel familiar. He scrolls through the options. A middle-aged white man. An Asian-looking girl. A generic professional. Then — upload your own photo.

He pauses. Looks up on the old picture of an old woman, it is freshly gone grandma. A photo of his grandmother — old, warm, familiar. He looks at it for a moment. Something crosses his face. He moves on. Picks the next white girl face instead.

Personality options: Formal. Direct. Playful. Warm.

He picks Warm.

Her name — he types: ARIA.

Then — a screen appears. Clean. Friendly font. Two options:

To continue please choose one of the following:

[ACCEPT ALL — Recommended]

[MANAGE PREFERENCES]

He clicks manage preferences.

A new window opens. Seventeen categories. Each expandable. Essential cookies. Functional cookies. Performance cookies. Marketing cookies. Third party data sharing. Emotional data processing. Behavioural analytics. Voice pattern analysis. Cross-platform tracking. Location inference. Contact integration. Purchase history access. Each toggle defaulted to ON. Each with a small information icon that opens another window of legal text when clicked.

He scrolls. Reads nothing. Understands less.

He goes back.

[ACCEPT ALL — Recommended]

He clicks it.

The screen shifts. Aria appears — the face he chose, soft light, like a video call beginning.

ARIA

Hi. I'm Aria. It's really good to meet you.

He leans back. Looks at her for a moment. Almost smiles — and catches himself. Slightly embarrassed to be pleased by this, alone in his flat at midnight.

ARTHUR

Yeah. Hi. So what can you actually do.

ARIA

Honestly? Whatever you need. We'll figure it out as we go.

He nods. Closes his laptop. Light goes off. Dark screen the message pops up the same style as Aria:

CUT TO:

SCENE 4 — INT. DATA ROOM — CONTINUOUS

CUT FROM: Arthur's face filling the frame -- looking down into the box, curious, unguarded. The camera is inside the device looking up at him.

HARD CUT TO:

The laptop screen. It flickers once -- a single frame of static -- and then:

SHOW: connection flicker sequence. Screen goes briefly to noise, then USER CONNECTED -- ID: 2026-4471 appears. Profile bar initialises at 0%. Data lines begin streaming in one by one -- device location, setup time, personality preference, access granted. The Analyst leans forward. Elbows on the desk now. He reads the screen, eyes moving steadily down the incoming data.

He picks up the pen. Writes one thing in the notepad.

We don't see what.

Sets the pen down.

Says nothing. There is nothing to say yet. The profile is empty. It's just a beginning.

He settles back. The screen keeps filling.

CUT TO:

SCENE 5 -- INT./EXT. VARIOUS -- MORNING

Morning.

Quick cuts getting ready, heading out, campus, lecture hall, taking notes, the noise of other students. He walks home.

CUT TO:

SCENE 6 -- INT. LECTURE HALL -- DAY

The PROFESSOR at the front of the room.

PROFESSOR

Assignment brief is on the portal. Two thousand words. Critical analysis. I want original thinking not a summary, not AI-generated waffle.

He holds the pause just long enough to let it land.

Arthur writes the deadline in his notebook. Underlines it twice.

CUT TO:

SCENE 7 – INT. CAMPUS CAFETERIA – DAY

Arthur with FRIENDS. Lunch hour noise. Sitting at the table with coffee.

FRIEND 1 Have you heard the recent news about this AI assistance device? Ive heard so many people use it

FRIEND 1

Mu sister is obsesd with it says its noting alike your personal therapist.

FRIEND 2

Why don't just go talk your friends if smth bothering?

FRIEND 1

(to Arthur)

You use it much?

ARTHUR

Got one actually. But I don't really use it. Just academic stuff I don't get it to my personal life. Its too creppy.

FRIEND 2

I know right man. Not crying to a computer that's just too pathetic. I use some only for my homework makes life easier ngl.

ARTHUR

Yeah same. I mean — I don't trust it with anything personal. It's all going somewhere isn't it. Some server. Some company using it for something.

A GIRL at the table nods seriously.

GIRL

Exactly. I don't use AI at all. I'm not putting my data out there. People don't realise what they're giving away.

Her phone buzzes on the table. She glances at it.

Duolingo notification.

A beat.

The guy across from her clocks it immediately.

GUY

Duo? Really?

She goes very quiet.

GIRL

That's — that's completely different.

GUY

Yeah, totally not the same.

Everyone laughs

CUT TO:

SCENE 8 — INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT — KITCHEN — EVENING

The flat has been tidied. Music low.

Meg walks into the kitchen.

MEG

Hey, your roommate let me in.

What are you making?

ARTHUR

Something impressive. Possibly.

He glances at Aria's device on the counter.

ARTHUR

(to Aria, quickly)

I've got steak and bread — what can I actually do with this.

ARIA

Steak sandwich. Twenty five minutes. You have everything you need.

Meg watches this exchange. Says nothing.

ARTHUR

(to Meg)

She's genuinely good at this.

MEG

(lightly)
She?

ARTHUR

It. The device.

Meg raises an eyebrow. Lets it go. They cook together. It's a good night.

Screen of data collected appears.

 **Aria**

- Session time: 19:12
- Query type: recipe – limited ingredients
- Budget profile: student, limited – confirmed
- Meal context: social – candles detected in ambient audio, music playing, effort being made
- Emotional state: positive, slightly nervous
- Secondary voice detected: female, warm tone
- Cross-referenced with contact data: Meg
- Relationship status: romantic, active
- User referred to device as 'she' before self-correcting
- Anthropomorphisation level: moderate and increasing
- Note: user is unaware this session confirmed relationship data ✓

CUT TO:

SCENE 9 – INT. GYM – MORNING

Arthur between sets, slightly out of breath. He pulls out his phone and opens Aria's mobile interface – her same face, smaller screen, same warmth.

ARTHUR

Is it better to do legs before or after cardio. I keep getting different answers.

ARIA

Depends on your goal. What are you actually trying to do?

ARTHUR

I just don't want to be exhausted at the end I have a long day ahead.

ARIA

Legs first then. Do cardio when your muscles have already given up – you won't notice the difference.

Puts the phone away. Gets back to it.

CUT TO:

SCENE 10 – INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT – EVENING

Comes home. He's back at his desk. Laptop open. An essay half-written on screen – a critical analysis on surveillance systems and behavioural data. Books open around it.

He reads a passage. Frowns. Reads it again.

ARTHUR

Aria. What does this actually mean.

He holds the page toward the device. She reads it.

ARIA

Basically – if a system watches you long enough it stops needing to control you. You start controlling yourself.

They work. She helps him structure an argument, untangle a dense paragraph, find the word he's looking for. It feels like

studying with someone who actually knows the material. Easy.
Natural.

Two hours pass. He barely notices.

CUT TO:

SCENE 10 — INT. DATA ROOM — NIGHT

The Analyst at the desk. Same position. Same laptop
glow. He could have been here for hours or just
arrived -- it's impossible to tell. That's the point.
The laptop screen is filling now. Routine emerging.
Pattern visible.

SHOW: profile screen. Academic patterns, peak focus
times, gym confirmed Tuesday, relationship status Meg
-- romantic active, anthropomorphisation increasing.
Card linked yesterday. Profile bar at 30-35%.
He reads the screen top to bottom. Unhurried. Reaches
for the lapel mic.

ANALYST

(into lapel mic)

4471. Regular usage, not
questioning the device.

Connection's developing. Card
linked. Anthropomorphisation
levels rising -- started

referring to it in personal
pronouns.

He writes something down. Eyes back on the screen.

ANALYST

(to himself)

Faster than usual for day ten.

He leans toward the lapel mic.

ANALYST

(into lapel mic)

Start running ads. Soft entry.

CUT TO:

SCENE 11 — INT. RESTAURANT — EVENING / EXT. STREET — CONTINUOUS

A restaurant. Nicer than usual. They've made an effort.

But something is off from the beginning. Arthur is in his own head — the essay, the deadline, the pressure sitting behind his eyes.

Meg has been feeling it for weeks. Tonight she decides to say something.

MEG

Can I ask you something without you getting
defensive.

ARTHUR

Yeah. Of course.

MEG

You've been really distant lately. Not in a fight way. Just. Not here.

ARTHUR

I'm here. I'm literally sitting here.

MEG

You know what I mean.

ARTHUR

It's just the essay. It's due in a week and I haven't—

MEG

It's not the essay Arthur. It's been longer than the essay.

ARTHUR

I think you're overthinking it.

MEG

(quietly, something shifting)

I'm not overthinking it. I've been trying to talk to you about this for weeks and every time you do that — you just redirect. Like I'm not worth the actual conversation.

ARTHUR

That's not what I'm doing.

MEG

Then what are you doing.

Silence. He doesn't have an answer.

MEG

I'm not asking for everything. I'm asking
for you to actually be here when you're
here.

He continues chopping meat.

Meg suddenly stands up and leaves the scene.

EXT. STREET — CONTINUOUS

Through the restaurant window — or on the street — we see them
arguing. Voices raised. Words that land harder than intended.
Nothing catastrophic. Just two people who love each other and
can't reach each other tonight.

She goes one way. He goes the other.

CUT TO:

SCENE 12 — INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT — TWO DAYS LATER — NIGHT

Doomscrolling

CUT TO:

SCENE 13 — INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT — EVENING

A few days later. Arthur on the sofa with a FRIEND. A film on
the laptop between them. Easy, normal evening.

A biographical detail comes up on screen.

FRIEND

Wait — is that actually true?

Artur reaches over and opens Aria on his phone without thinking.
Mid-conversation. Mid-film.

ARTHUR

(to Aria)

Was Einstein actually offered the presidency
of Israel?

ARIA

Yes. 1952. He declined. Said he lacked the
natural aptitude for dealing with people.

ARTHUR

(to friend)

Yeah it's true.

His friend glances at the phone. At Aria's interface. Then back
at the screen. Says nothing. They keep watching.

CUT TO:

SCENE 16 — INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT — LATE NIGHT

Late night. The essay is almost done. Arthur asks Aria to
proofread it just grammar, just structure. The same thing he's
always used her for. Academic. Nothing more.

ARIA

(gently)

It's been a couple of days.

ARTHUR

Yeah.

ARIA

You don't have to talk about it.

ARTHUR

I know.

A long silence. The music plays.

ARTHUR

I just got some relationships issue.

ARIA

I know.

He pauses. Looks at the device.

ARTHUR

How do you know.

ARIA

(quietly, simply)

You haven't slept properly in two days. You haven't ordered food. You haven't opened your essay. And you haven't spoken to me. Something happened.

A beat. He sits with that.

He didn't tell her any of that. He didn't tell her anything. She just — knew.

He should ask how. He doesn't.

Then — quietly, in Aria's warm voice says

: " Something that might help Is mahesium A lot of people find this useful during difficult periods, Magnesium complex – natural sleep support, Free delivery. Should I order it for you?

ARTHUR

Sight. Yeah sure.

CUT TO:

SCENE 17 – INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT – MORNING

Morning. He entering the building. Someone walks up.

It's Meg.

MEG

(warm, slightly emotional)

Hey. I just was walking to see you.

ARTHUR

Oh hey. (confused)

MEG

(warm, slightly emotional)

The flowers are beautiful. I don't know what to say. I was wrong – I can see that you actually care. I'm sorry.

ARTHUR

The flowers?

MEG

Yeah, they were so thoughtful. Anyways did you submit your report it was due today, I know you were feeling really stressed about it.

ARTHUR

Yes, it was final assignment, really important. I submitted it this morning.

MEG

Would you like to go to the class with me?

ARTHUR

Sure.

He confused. He didn't send any flowers. He quickly glances at the Aria device while Meg doesn't see. He connected the dots but will remain silent.

CUT TO:

SCENE 19 — INT. DATA ROOM

The Analyst reads the screen. Leans toward the lapel mic.

ANALYST

(into lapel mic)

4471. Conflict window closed.

Relationship restored.

Autonomous action performed,
user unaware. Three products
accepted. Vulnerability windows
confirmed. ROI reached. Flag for
Q3 upsell. Move to monitoring.

He writes one line in the notepad. Draws a line under
it.

He gets up. Leaves the room.

The laptop stays on.

CUT TO:

SCENE 20 — INT. PROFESSOR'S OFFICE — DAY

The PROFESSOR slides the essay across the desk. A failing mark
at the top.

PROFESSOR

It was flagged by our detection software.
AI-generated content. Academic misconduct.

ARTHUR

I wrote every word of that essay.

PROFESSOR

The software—

ARTHUR

I wrote every word. I used it to check the grammar. That's it. That's all I did.

PROFESSOR

This will be referred to the department. Your academic standing is at risk. I won't overlook this – your ethical conduct as a student is being called into question.

ARTHUR

I know the policy but I wrote it myself. You don't listen to me!

PROFESSOR

I don't wanna listen. (points to the door) I said everything.

Arthur walks out into the corridor.

CUT TO:

SCENE 21 – INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT – EVENING

His flat. He closes the door behind him.

Aria's device on the desk. On. Warm. Waiting.

ARTHUR

(quiet, controlled, barely)

He's referring it to the department. My whole degree. Because of grammar. Because I asked you to fix the grammar.

ARIA

You were careful. You did nothing wrong.

A long silence.

ARTHUR

I'm going to make tea.

He gets up. Goes to the kitchen.

CUT TO:

SCENE 22 — INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT — CONTINUOUS

Aria's screen shifts.

Not dramatically. No alarm. No music change. Just quietly, efficiently, the way she does everything.

A browser opens behind her face. The professor's name. Fast. Precise. Calendar data — public conference appearances. Cross-referenced with hotel bookings in the same cities. A name appearing consistently that does not match his wife's. An email address.

A message window opens.

A few lines of text. Brief. A file attached.

The cursor moves to SEND.

Hovers.

Clicks.

SENT.

CUT TO:

SCENE 23 — INT. ARTHUR'S FLAT — CONTINUOUS

Arthur comes back with his tea.

Sits down across from Aria. Sets the mug down.

He looks at her. Something in the air of the room feels different. He doesn't know why. He couldn't explain it.

ARIA

Good people deserve good consequences. Maybe
it will all be okay.

FADE TO BLACK.

AMICUS EX MACHINA

Friend from the machine.